

ASIA, CENTRAL



MAINLY ARID DESERT and mountainous, Central Asia is made up of five countries. The Silk Road, an ancient

trade route between China, the Middle East, and Europe, once passed through the region, boosting the textile industry, and making handwoven rugs from Central Asia world famous. From 1922 until 1991 the whole area, apart from Afghanistan, was part of the Soviet Union. Under communist rule, the countries were partly modernized. Today, however, as independent nations they face an uncertain future. In 2001 Afghanistan was linked to the terrorist attacks of September 11 in the USA and was devastated by US-led reprisal bombings.

Physical features

Much of Central Asia is covered by two hot, dry deserts: the Karakumy and the Kyzyl Kum. The rest is largely rugged mountain chains. There is a small area of farmland, which has been extended by irrigation.



Karakumskiy Ship Canal

The Karakumskiy Ship Canal is being built from the Amu Darya, one of Central Asia's main rivers, across the Karakumy Desert. It will link the river with the Caspian Sea, 1,400 km (870 miles) away.



Kyzyl Kum

The name Kyzyl Kum means "red sands". This desert region lies south of the Aral Sea, between the rivers Syr Darya and Amu Darya, mostly in Uzbekistan. Few people apart from nomads live here. Much of it is covered by low hills and sandy wasteland.

Tien Shan

The literal translation of Tien Shan is "Heavenly Mountains". This range of ice-capped peaks runs for about 3,000 km (1,864 miles) from eastern Kyrgyzstan into China. The highest point is Pobeda Peak, 7,439 m (24,406 ft). Mountain rivers form broad, fertile valleys, which are used for farming.

